Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "Fancy in Nubibus"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Coleridge's poem include

alliteration,
allusion,
analogy,
assonance,
auditory imagery,
couplet,
elision,
English (Shakespearean) sonnet,
esemplastic,
imagination,
metaphor,
mood / tone,
quatrain,
rhyme scheme, and
visual imagery.

Coleridge's sonnet suggests a mediation-as-mental-journey. In addressing the role of the imagination in a poet's encounter with the natural world, the young writer should focus on the poet's imagery, both visual and auditory. The poem's speaker reflects on several analogies in which the imagination takes control: "It is pleasant," he says, and then he reiterates this sentiment in the sequencing "or" in lines 5 and 10. The final analogy, wherein the imagery shifts from visual to auditory, likens the imagination-in-the-present to Homer as the creative fountain, "the inward light," of the Western world.

The contestant might recognize in Coleridge's visual sequence—the "shifting clouds," the shifting clouds as transformed by another's imaginative mind ("a friend's fancy"), and then the travelling upward, perhaps toward divine afflatus, through Cloudland itself—a crescendo from merely delighting in the beauty of nature to the transforming power of the imagination, which is Coleridge's esemplatic power (the imagination's "moulding into a unity" that which it "sees" [see *Handbook* 182]).

The student of literary criticism might further recognize the extinguishing of the visual, the loss of sight ("closèd sight / [. . .] blind bard"), as a necessary threshold to being able to "see" as a poet-in-the-clouds, more specifically, to allowing the power of the imagination to replace the several abilities of the senses that are usually associated with the poet's mundane, by comparison, powers of description.